

Module #3

CPC's "Reformed" and "Presbyterian" Distinctiveness

Introduction: Our "evangelical" context

Could it be said of us,

they have a zeal for God but not according to knowledge.

Romans 10:2

Here is what Richard Lints says about evangelicals:

It is not so much that evangelicals cease to believe anything theological, it is rather that belief is no longer central to their identity and program!

Richard Lints, Fabric of Theology

Three evangelical traits that work against theology:

In America the principal mediator of God's voice has not been state, church, council, confession, ethnic group, university college or seminary; it has been quite simply, the people... the impulse to rework Christianity into forms that were unmistakably popular... and democratic in at least three respects: it was audience centered, intellectually open to all, and organizationally pluralistic and innovative.

Nathan Hatch, "Evangelicalism as a Democratic Movement"

✓ Democratic

A curious effect of this emphasis on the subjective leading of the Spirit was the growth in power of the "popular popes" of evangelicalism. Though highly individualistic in their approach to salvation and populist in their biblical interpretation, populist Bible teachers and preachers served to draw people together into a mass movement largely through the strength of their personal popularity. As Mark Noll puts it, "Evangelical interpretation assigned first place to popular approval.

Rick Lints, *Fabric* p. 35

Compare:

Matt. 7:13 "Enter through the narrow gate; for the gate is wide and the road is easy that leads to destruction, and there are many who take it. 14 For the gate is narrow and the road is hard that leads to life, and there are few who find it.

Matt. 22:14 For many are called, but few are chosen.

✓ Anti-Intellectualistic

Expecting that great freedom of thought would generate great ideas, he found instead that Americans easily became "slaves of slogans... expecting to find priests, he found politicians." N. Hatch about Tocqueville

By thus admitting the sovereignty of the audience, evangelicals, knowingly or not, undercut the structure that could support critical theological thinking...the new ground rules for theology, opening it to all, meant that the measure of theology would be its acceptability in the marketplace of ideas. This meant that uncomfortable complexity would be flattened out, that issues would be resolved by a simple choice of alternatives, and that in many cases the fine distinctions from which truth alone can emerge were lost in the din of ideological battle.

Nathan Hatch

Compare:

Rom. 12:2 Do not be conformed to this world, but be transformed by the renewing of your minds, so that you may discern what is the will of God--what is good and acceptable and perfect.

2Cor. 10:5 Casting down imaginations, and every high thing that exalteth itself against the knowledge of God, and bringing into captivity every thought to the obedience of Christ

✓ Individualistic and Pluralistic

For Americans, the traditional relationship between the individual and the religious community is to some degree reversed. On the basis of our interviews, we are not surprised to learn that a 1978 Gallop poll found that 80 percent of Americans agreed that "an individual should arrive at his or her own religious beliefs independent of any church or synagogue." From the traditional point of view, this is a strange statement-- it is precisely within the church or synagogue that one comes to one's religious beliefs-- but to many Americans it is the Gallop finding that is normal.

Robert Bellah et. al. *Habits of the Heart, Individualism and Commitment in American Life*

Disassociate religion from social authority and high culture, let religion adapt to every status group through every variety of pulsating sectarianism. The result is that nobody feels ill at ease with his religion, that faith is distributed along the political spectrum, that church is never *the* axis of dispute.

David Martin, p. 77 of N. Hatch's "Democratization"

Compare:

1 Timothy 3:15, *the household of God... the church of the living God, the pillar and bulwark of the truth.*

Eph. 1:22 And He put all things under His feet, and gave Him to be head over all things to the church, 23 which is His body, the fullness of Him who **fills all in all**.

Eph. 2:19 ¶ Now, therefore, you are no longer strangers and foreigners, but fellow citizens with the saints and members of the household of God, 20 having been built on the foundation of the apostles and prophets, Jesus Christ Himself being the chief cornerstone, 21 in whom the whole building, being joined together, grows into a holy temple in the Lord, 22 in whom you also are being built **together** for a **dwelling place of God** in the Spirit.

I. The Importance of *Confessionalism* in the Church

What is "Confessionalism?"

Confessionalism is the process whereby the church adopts a corporate consensus as to what the scriptures principally teach, based upon shared exegetical conclusions and utilizes this consensus as the basis for Christian faith, practice and unity when acting as a church. Stated plainly, the *confessional* church is any church whose identity is most essentially "what it believes" and whose beliefs drives "what it does."

Let the Redeemed of the Lord say so... Ps.107:2

The Ultimate Goal of Confessionalism: To Preserve the Apostolic Faith, not supplant it!

Our own confession teaches about itself that it is fallible (WCF 1:9, 31.3) and that "all controversies of religion are to be determined, and all decrees of councils, opinions of ancient writers, doctrines of men and private spirits are to be examined and in whose

sentence we are to rest, can be no other but the Holy Spirit speaking in the Scripture" (WCF 1.10). And yet, without a "corporate reading of scripture as within the organizational structure established by Christ through the apostles (Mt. 16, Eph. 2), we are left with private interpretations and a corporate identity crisis.

Mt. 28:20, teaching them to observe all that I have commanded you...

Acts 20:26-27, Therefore I declare to you this day that I am not responsible for the blood of any of you, for I did not shrink from declaring to you the whole counsel of God

2 Thess.2:15, So then, brothers and sisters, stand firm and hold fast to the traditions that you were taught by us, either by word of mouth or by our letter.

A Biblical History of Confessing

- An Intrinsic quality of faith-- *Let the Redeemed of the Lord say so... Ps.107:2*
- A Confessing history of Israel-- see Dt.6:4-9, 26:5-9
- Peter's Confession--see Mt.16:13-18
- Perhaps the earliest and briefest Christian confession--1 Cor.12:3, "Jesus is Lord."
- Early Apostolic "statements"--Rom.1:3-4, 1Cor.15:3-4, 1Tim.3:16
- A call to confess--Rom.10:9, 1 Cor.11:2, 12:3, Jude 3, 2Thess.2:15

The Use of Creeds to support Confessionalism

A "creed" is any summary and/or clarification of a certain belief. (The word "Creed" is derived from the Latin word "belief.") Therefore, a Christian creed is an interpretation of the general teachings of the Old and New Testament Scriptures categorized into general themes and topics of relevance to the Christian faith and subscribed to by the church.

2 Timothy 1:13, Follow the pattern of the sound words which you have heard from me, in the faith and love which are in Christ Jesus.

2 Thess.2:15, So then, brothers and sisters, stand firm and hold fast to the traditions that you were taught by us, either by word of mouth or by our letter.

The Usefulness of Creeds: (Quotes by A.A. Hodge)

1. As a basis for Christian Unity

To act as the bond of ecclesiastical fellowship among those so nearly agreed as to be able to labor together in harmony.

Amos 3:3, "How can two walk together unless they be agreed?"

Phil. 1:27, "stand fast in one spirit with one mind"

1 Cor.1:10, "speak the same thing and be on one accord of one mind"

Philip. 2:2, Make my joy complete, be of the same mind, having the same love, being in full accord and of one mind.

Eph. 4:4, "There is one body and one Spirit, just as you were called to one hope of your calling, one Lord, one faith, one baptism.

Eph.4:13, "until all of us come to the unity of the faith and of the knowledge of the son of God.

If not unity of "faith" then unity of what?

2. For Instruction

To be used as instruments in the great work of popular instruction.

1 Tim. 4:6, If you put these instructions before the brothers and sisters, you will be a good servant of Christ Jesus, nourished on the words of faith and of the sound teaching that you have followed.

1 Tim. 6:3, Whoever teaches otherwise and does not agree with the sound words of our Lord Jesus Christ and the teaching that is in accordance with godliness...

2 Tim. 4:3, For the time is coming when people will not put up with sound doctrine, but having itching ears, they will accumulate for themselves teachers to suit their own desires.

3. For Ecclesiastical Discipline

Acts 20:28 Keep watch over yourselves and over all the flock, of which the Holy Spirit has made you overseers, to shepherd the church of God that he obtained with the blood of his own Son.

Heb. 13:17 Obey your leaders and submit to them, for they are keeping watch over your souls and will give an account. Let them do this with joy and not with sighing--for that would be harmful to you.

4. As a basis for evaluating true from false teaching and teacher qualification.

To discriminate the truth from the glosses of false teachers, and accurately to define it in its integrity and due proportions.

Romans 10:2, they have a zeal for God but not according to knowledge.

2Pet. 2:1-2 But false prophets also arose among the people, just as there will be false teachers among you, who will secretly bring in destructive opinions. They will even deny the Master who bought them--bringing swift destruction on themselves. Even so, many will follow their licentious ways, and because of these teachers the way of truth will be maligned.

2John 1:10 Do not receive into the house or welcome anyone who comes to you and does not bring this teaching;

5. For Preserving the "Faith of our Fathers" such as to better protect against cultural "blind-spots."

To mark, preserve, and disseminate the attainments made in the knowledge of Christian truth by any branch of the church in any grand crisis of its development.

2Tim. 2:2 and what you have heard from me through many witnesses entrust to faithful people who will be able to teach others as well.

II. Our "Confessional" history... a brief historical review

- Other families:
 - Pre-Reformation Period: East, West (Rome, Constantinople)
 - Reformation Period: Lutheran, Anabaptist, Reformed...
 - Post-Reformation: Presbyterian, Baptist, Episcopalian, Methodist...
 - Modern: Fundamentalism, Liberal, Charismatic, etc.)
- E.g. We are "Christians" before we are "reformed Christians" and share together such expressions of faith as articulated by:
 - The Council of Nicaea (A.D.325)
 - The Council of Constantinople (A.D.381)
 - Both were especially related to the doctrine of God, the Trinity, Historicity of Salvation Accomplished and Applied.

- Our Family Tree, assuming it begins with Apostolic foundation, continues with Augustine and proceeds through Calvin, especially regarding our understanding of how God saves us from the penalty and misery of our sin.
- 5th Century A.D.—Pelagius vs. Augustine
Humankind born innocent vs. original sin... humankind responsible in salvation vs. saved by grace through faith alone “to the praise of God’s glorious grace” (Eph.1:3-14, 2:10ff). Pelagianism rejected at Synod of Carthage in A.D. 418. It was again rejected at Council of Ephesus in A.D. 431.
- 16th Century A.D.-- Our most “important” immediate ancestor? John Calvin (1509-1564) and thus the word Calvinism”
 - Calvin’s reliance upon Augustine’s theology, especially against Pelagianism
 - Calvin’s earlier contemporary and theological ally, Huldrych Zwingli (1484-1531) where together allied and associated with the reforms of Martin Luther (1484-1546)
 - Calvin’s most significant followers including such leaders as Heinrich Bullinger (1504-1575), Theodore Beza (1519-1605) and John Knox (1514-1572)
- 16th Century A.D. -- Pelagianism reappeared through Dutch theologian named Arminius—(Arminianism or “Semi-Pelagianism”)
 - Humankind only partially fallen rather than not fallen at all, but with the same result as Pelagianism—both assume human responsibility
 - Arminianism specifically rejected at the Synod of Dort in A.D. 1618-1619.
- 16th-17th Century A.D. - Reformed Confessional Tradition is further expressed various other significant contexts:
 - The Scots Confession (1560)—approved by Reformation Parliament and Church of Scotland, attaining full legal status with the departure of Mary, Queen of Scots in 1567.
 - The Genevan Confession (1536)—together with a translation of Calvin’s Catechism (1541)
 - The Second Helvetic Confession (1561) and approved by General Assembly in 1566 in the Reformed Scottish Church.
 - Heidelberg Catechism (1563)
 - Westminster Confession (1646)
 - Helvetic Consensus Formula (1675 A.D.)

Therefore, in a family context, reformed Christians have discerned the need to “say so” as the redeemed people of the Lord (Ps.107:2)

So what is it? E.g. What do all these family histories as rooted in the Augustine-Calvin family tree have in common? What is the “reformed” *emphasis*?

III. The Reformed Distinctiveness

The “five points of Calvinism”—T.U.L.I.P.

- ✓ Total Depravity: or “not to deny common grace wherein God preserves some goodness in humanity for the common good, but that there is no goodness in humanity that is

pure and without defect of moral imperfection and capable of satisfying God's holy standard of righteousness."

- ✓ Unconditional Election: or "conditioned only upon God's immutable, eternal, perfect counsel and omnipotent will."
- ✓ Limited Atonement: or "Christ's death is applied only to the elect"
- ✓ Irresistible Grace: or "God's grace is received only by those who are given faith by the Holy Spirit through "new birth" unto "newness of life."
- ✓ Perseverance of the Saints: or "The perseverance of God on behalf of the saints such that God is faithful, even when we are faithless, to enable us over and over again to confession, repentance of self-trust and faith in God for our salvation."

3. TULIP Revisited—F.A.I.T.H. (from Jim Osternhouse)

- ✓ *Fallen Humankind*—people are by nature completely unwilling morally and unable functionally to save themselves from sin and its consequences...

Rom. 1:18ff, Rom. 5:12ff, Rom. 3:23ff, Eph. 2:1

- ✓ *Adopted by God*—Based on God's own, self-sufficient character of love, God has chosen some people to be members of his family to the praise of his glorious grace.
Eph. 1:3-12, John 6:35-40, Acts. 13:48

- ✓ *Intentional Atonement*—Jesus took the penalty of God's justice against sin upon himself in order to save his people from taking the eternal consequences themselves.

Rom. 3:23-26, Heb. 5:4, Heb. 5:5, John 5:22, John 5:27, Matt. 28:18, Eph. 1:4, "

: "The business of man's salvation was transacted upon covenant terms between the Father and the Son from all eternity... What grace was that which was given us in Christ before the world began, but this grace of redemption which was from everlasting thus contrived and designed for us, in that way which hath been here opened? "

John Flavel p.61

For whom does Jesus lay down his life... for everyone?

John 10:14

I am the good shepherd. I know my own and my own know me, 15 just as the Father knows me and I know the Father. And I lay down my life for the sheep.

- ✓ *Transformed by the Holy Spirit*—The Holy spirit regenerates those who are chosen by God, starting with giving them faith in Jesus and continually working more and more faith and godliness in them until their perfect glorification at death.

1Cor. 2:14, Rom. 5:5, Acts 16:14, Eph. 2:8

God did not just provide us with a potential salvation (offering salvation through the atoning work of Christ (objective)... but actual salvation (because of the salvation the Holy Spirit enables us to have by faith!)

- ✓ *Held by God*—Believers are held safe in God's family and plan of salvation for all eternity.

Rom. 8: 35-39, Philip. 1:6, 1Pet. 1:3-5, John 10:24-30

A Doxological Theology

"Men treat God's sovereignty as a theme for controversy, but in Scripture it is matter for worship." (J.I.Packer)

According to the Reformers and the Puritans, the message of Christianity is not simply about how man is to be saved, it is about how God is glorified in man's salvation.

Ian Murray

Whatever else is "true" about good religion, it is first and foremost about God!

I am the Alpha and the Omega," says the Lord God, who is and who was and who is to come, the Almighty. (Rev. 1:8)

"Now the knowledge of God, as I understand it, is that by which we not only conceive that there is a God but also grasp what befits us and is proper to his glory, in fine, what is to our advantage to know of him. Indeed, we shall not say that, properly speaking, God is known where there is no religion or piety." (Book 1, Ch. 2, 1)

What help is it, in short to know a God with whom we have nothing to do? Rather our knowledge should serve first to teach us fear and reverence, secondly with it as our guide and teacher we should learn to seek every good from him and having received it to credit it to his account." (Book 1, Ch. 2, 2)

John Calvin

WCF 2.1-2

There is but one only, living, and true God, who is infinite in being and perfection, a most pure spirit, invisible, without body, parts, or passions; immutable, immense, eternal, incomprehensible, almighty, most wise, most holy, most free, most absolute; working all things according to the counsel of his own immutable and most righteous will, for his own glory; most loving, gracious, merciful, long-suffering, abundant in goodness and truth, forgiving iniquity, transgression, and sin; the rewarder of them that diligently seek him; and withal, most just, and terrible in his judgments, hating all sin, and who will by no means clear the guilty. God hath all life, glory, goodness, blessedness, in and of himself; and is alone in and unto himself all-sufficient, not standing in need of any creatures which he hath made, nor deriving any glory from them, but only manifesting his own glory in, by, unto, and upon them. He is the alone fountain of all being, of whom, through whom, and to whom are all things; and hath most sovereign dominion over them, to do by them, for them, or upon them whatsoever himself pleaseth. In his sight all things are open and manifest, his knowledge is infinite, infallible, and independent upon the creature, so as nothing is to him contingent, or uncertain. He is most holy in all his counsels, in all his works, and in all his commands. ***To him is due from angels and men, and every other creature, whatsoever worship, service, or obedience he is pleased to require of them.***

IV. Reformed in Context to Other Religions/Christian Families:

What makes a visible church?

Eg. See Policy on Roman "denomination"

A visible church is an organization that self-consciously traces its origin to Christ and seeks to build upon the foundation established by the apostles upon the cornerstone of Christ. (Eph. 2:20ff)

The apostolic foundation of the visible church upon the cornerstone of Christ is basically Christ mediating his salvific presence through the three defining marks of the church in her ministry of word, sacrament and government as corresponding to his prophetic, priestly

and kingly office, (See "church an essential...)

WCF 25.3. Unto this catholic visible Church Christ hath given the ministry, oracles, and ordinances of God, for the gathering and perfecting of the saints, in this life, to the end of the world: and doth, by His own presence and Spirit, according to His promise, make them effectual thereunto.

The visible church can, to lesser or greater degrees be in error, but not so as to violate the fundamentals of the Christian faith as historically recognized in the so called ecumenical creeds (as distinguished from the reformational creeds) in so far as they conform to the standard established by the apostles (as for instance 1 John)

WCF 25.4. This catholic Church hath been sometimes more, sometimes less visible. And particular Churches, which are members thereof, are more or less pure, according as the doctrine of the Gospel is taught and embraced, ordinances administered, and public worship performed more or less purely in them.

WCF 25.5. The purest Churches under heaven are subject both to mixture and error; and some have so degenerated as to become no Churches of Christ, but synagogues of Satan. Nevertheless, there shall be always a Church on earth to worship God according to His will.

A " visible church" is defined by its ministry of word, sacraments and government, all to at least minimally preserve the "apostolic" content pertaining to each as minimally affirmed by the so called "ecumenical creeds" as historically understood in its intended and literal sense.

For example:

The Nicene Creed

Note The Value of Denominationalism:

Preserves Unity along Confessional Lines, while allowing confessionalism to go beyond the "essentials" as per the gospel.

E.g. Unity is both "as wide as the gospel is wide" and as "Comprehensive as the gospel is comprehensive"

Alternative— The politically strong impose its "confession" on the politically weak- no significant place for decent or anathematize everyone who doesn't agree.

Freedom of conscience in tension with ecclesial government...

Who are we historically:

1. Apostolic vs. Other World Religions--- A Christ Centered Faith
Eph. 2:17-22

- ✓ Polytheism
- ✓ Monism

Vs. Trinitarian

Representative Creeds: Apostles Creed, Nicene Creed, etc.

2. Eastern Orthodoxy vs. Western Orthodoxy (by this I mean the E. Orthodox church, not necessarily middle east/pan-asian)

- ✓ Word/cognitive based spirituality vs. “imagery, mystery, and community” based spirituality
 - Therefore, a
 - ✓ Original sin as per rebellion against God vs. original fall in that we “lost our way”
 - Therefore, a lower view of sin which requires a less radical and fundamental correction
 - Difference between our losing fellowship with God vs. never really had it and lost our way toward getting it.
 - ✓ Grace requires Penal Substitution (as a free unmerited atonement from sin by the historic work of Christ and received by faith alone) vs. Mystical union and Guidance viewed as a divine energy or power that is transmitted to penitents, enabling them to return to the pathway of fellowship with and acceptance by God.
 - ✓ Salvation means “justification” as an act of God’s free grace accomplished by Christ vs. salvation means “theosis” or the process of becoming acceptable to God by becoming “like” God-in love, mercy, and justice in fellowship with Him.
E.O.—We are finally accepted by God at the end of the long process of “theosis.”
3. Protestant vs. “Catholic”—a “Christ vs. Christ plus” gospel (The 5 reformational “sola’s)
- ✓ Sola Scriptura: Christ speaking through Scripture as our only rule for faith and practice. (vs. Christ in scripture AND church (ecumenical councils))
 - ✓ Sola Fide: Justification by faith alone vs. faith plus sacraments/works... Only by God’s grace through faith alone are we saved (even as true faith is never alone), not by any works of our own. vs. Grace through the effectual application of it by the sacraments (baptism, mass, penance, etc) and good works until we are perfectly sanctified, at which time we are justified... thus the need for purgatory, etc.
 - ✓ Sola Gratia—salvation, from beginning to end, is entirely God’s work vs. salvation required human cooperation
 - ✓ Sola Christus— Christ alone is the priest of all believers: Our access to God is through Christ alone as the only redeemer of God’s people. (vs. a human succession of the priesthood)
 - ✓ Sola Deo Gloria—To God alone is all glory honor and power... Church is a “means” of grace vs. “agent” of grace

Our “issues” with the Roman Catholic Church is that the Catholic church has so added to the sufficiency of Christ as to severely *diminish* the power of the gospel while not all together mitigating it. So for instance, we believe that the exclusive crown rights of Christ as head and king over his church is significantly undermined by the Catholic doctrine of papal infallibility albeit not contrary to but beside the authority of Christ (see WCF 25:6). We are also concerned that exclusive authority and wisdom of Christ as divine prophet as through the Old and New Testament scriptures has been significantly undermined by the Catholic church in its later addition of the so called Apocrypha as also having scriptural authority (see WCF 1:3), together with the RC doctrine of continuing revelation through the proclamations of the church even if not contrary to the scriptures but beside the scripture in authoritative teaching (see WCF 1:6). We are likewise concerned that the Catholic church has undermined the sufficiency of Christ’s once and for all priestly sacrifice as an atonement for the sins of the elect by its teaching of a continued sacrifice in her doctrine of transubstantiation as then under the exercise and control of the church (see WCF 29:2,5-6). We are finally deeply concerned that the gospel as by faith *alone* is significantly undermined

by the Catholic church's doctrines concerning justification as to require the necessary and complete "infusion" of divine righteousness (what Protestants consider to be the ongoing process of sanctification that is after justification) rather than as understood to be the imputation of righteousness so as to no longer live in fear of God's condemnation by faith alone that is prior to sanctification (See for instance the RC language concerning justification in Catechism of the Catholic Church, # 1989, 1993 and then #1995)

In sum, we are concerned that the RC faith is prone to what has been described as "sacerdotalism" wherein the RC church is effectively the agent of grace (rather than an instrument or "means" of grace) such that salvation is applied to the elect *necessarily* by the church. Whereas we affirm that the church as an essential element of the gospel, it is not essential as the *agent* of grace (the Holy Spirit) but as the Holy Spirit's divinely instituted *means* of grace ordinarily, if not necessarily.

Representative Creeds,

- The Scots Confession (1560)—approved by Reformation Parliament and Church of Scotland, attaining full legal status with the departure of Mary, Queen of Scots in 1567.
- The Genevan Confession (1536)—together with a translation of Calvin's Catechism (1541)
- The Second Helvetic Confession (1561) and approved by General Assembly in 1566 in the Reformed Scottish Church.
- Heidelberg Catechism (1563)
- Westminster Confession (1646)
- Helvetic Consensus Formula (1675 A.D.)

3. Classical Protestant vs. Modernist Protestant ("evangelical") vs. (liberal)

- ✓ Miracles: We do believe in an "open system" universe such that salvation is rooted in miraculous works of redemption in history.
Among other things:
 - a. Historic resurrection of Christ
 - b. Historical Miracles
 - c. Historic miraculous conception wherein Christ is both divine and human
- ✓ Infallibility and Inerrancy of Scriptures vs. Modern criticism
- ✓ Supernatural Conversion vs. Moralism: Personal and super-natural Conversion through repentance and Faith by the regeneration of the Holy Spirit (one must be "born again", even if gradually over time or "abruptly.")
- ✓ Atonement Gospel vs. Social Gospel
- ✓ Exclusivity of Christ vs. Universality of All Religions

Representative creeds/statements: Lausanne Covenant, Chicago Statement of Inerrancy

4. Evangelical Reformed vs. Evangelical Armenian/Pelagian (Old School Evangelical /New School Evangelical)

- ✓ Salvation by sovereign grace of God vs. Salvation by human cooperation with grace (which then would cease to be grace at all)

Logical order of salvation events: Election, effectual calling (regeneration), conversion (repentance and faith), Justification, adoption, sanctification, assurance, perseverance, glorification.

I.e. Predestination Vs. Foreknowledge as to human cooperation...

6. Sacramentalist vs. Memorialist (Presbyterian/Episcopalian/Methodist/Congregationalist vs. Baptist/Community/"Bible")

- a. The Church is Christology Applied:
Prophetic office now mediated through Authorized Preaching
Priestly office now mediated through Prayer and Sacraments
Kingly office now mediated through authorized "shepherds"/elders
- b. The Apostolic succession of the ministry through the passing down of apostolic standards/qualifications as recognized by the church.
The language of "appoint" as applied to the offices of ministry is clearly used in the pastoral Epistles. This is significant since the pastoral Epistles were written as instructions for the church as it was to continue on after the apostolic era (Titus 1:5). The appointment of "officers" (however one may name them) in the church is accompanied by the "laying of hands" first by the apostles (Acts 8:18) and later by the "presbytery" (1 Tim. 4:14, KJV), indicating an authorization that is ultimately traced back to Christ insofar as he authorized the apostles to do this (Mat. 16:18, Eph. 2:20). Therefore, where we do not hold to a human succession traced through human lineage as the Roman church does, we do recognize a lineage that has been handed down through "presbyteries," or that "corporate body" called the "church" in 1 Tim. 3:15, which is the guardian of the Truth
- c. The Church Has a Sacramental Gospel vs. merely a rationalistic gospel
I.e. The gospel is not merely a saving "idea" but also a saving "presence" as mediated by Christ through the means of grace in the church.
Revelations 21:3-4 from Lev. 26:9, Eph. 1:22-23, Eph. 2:19-22
E.g. Covenant Theology vs. Individual Theology of Church

- ✓ Two or Three Office view of Church Government
- ✓ Covenant Theology of Salvation and Church: i.e. Infant Baptism vs. anti-infant baptism (note-- we do believe our children are believers albeit unconfirmed... thus not to be distinguished from "credo-baptistic) views.

Whatever be the true theory of the origin of civil society, yet in regard to the relations of the church, as originally an outgrowth of the family, we are not left to speculation. It is distinctly declared to have thus originated. For a series of generations, the family was the only divinely appointed government. In the family, as a government, were lodged both State and church; the head of the family being both magistrate and priest...When that family increased to a nation of three millions of people, the church was re-organized, and adapted to the new circumstances. It became now a distinct government, embracing many families as *families*, for not only were the families theoretically the constituent element of the government, but the actual representation in the government was by heads of families – elders of the people. And when in the fullness of time, the last and complete organization of the church took place under apostles, specially commissioned by Christ, to do for the church what the convention of 1789 did for the American people; and the church of one nation was adapted to become the church of all nations; the same principle was announced, – "the promise is to you and to your children." When a citizen was received under the new form of naturalization, "he and all his household" were thereby received. And hence, the record makes allusion to the church that is in the

house of Aquila and Priscilla, of Nymphas, and of Philemon. (Rom. 16:G; Col. 4:15; and Phil. 1:2.) In accordance with these statements of the Scripture, our standards declare "The visible church consists of all those throughout the world that profess the true religion, *together with their children.*" And this, as distinguished from "the invisible church," which "consists of the whole number of the elect that have been, are, or shall be gathered into one, under Christ the head thereof; and is the spouse, the body, the fullness of Him that filleth all in all."
Stuart Robinson

- ✓ Directory Approach to Worship (vs. Form prescription (Episcopal) or Form freedom- (Baptist))

Representative Creeds: Westminster Confession vs. London Baptist Confession...

6. Representative/Connectional Polity vs. Independent and either hierarchial or congregational

- ✓ Connectional vs. Independent

An organic understanding of the "connected" church vs. independent church

The organic concept of the church that appears in the New Testament... presents a more theological, Christ-centered, spiritual view of the church as defined not by one earthly hierarchial center nor by many earthly congregational centers, but by a heavenly center that requires multiform earthly manifestations. Earthly assemblies do not define but manifest the nature and the center of the church.

Edmund Clowney

- ✓ Representative elders vs. congregational or hierarchial

1. Prelacy: administered by archbishops, bishops, deans, archdeacons and other ecclesiastical offices on a hierarchial system by hierarchial appointment vs. representative or congregational determined offices. All things are general. (Roman Catholic, Episcopal, Greek Orthodox, Methodist)

James Bannerman:

The Proper and essential distinction between the two systems is the assertion by Episcopalians and the denial by Presbyterians of Scriptural warrant for a third order of ordinary and permanent office-bearers in the Church above presbyters and deacons, having exclusively in their hands the "power of ordination" and the "power of jurisdiction." (Vol.2, p.263-4)

In other words, the difference asserted by the Episcopalian theory between the order of bishops and the order of presbyters is exhibited in the right belonging to bishops, and not to presbyters, of ordaining to office in the Church and further, in the power of appertaining to bishops and not to presbyters, of exercising government and administering discipline in the Christian society.

2. Independency: Each separate congregation is under Christ subject to no external jurisdiction. All things are local.

Congregational Independency (Baptist, Congregationalism)

Representative Independency (Reformed Baptist)

3. Presbyterianism: Representative government that enjoy jurisdictional/ecclesiastical connectedness to other churches within same denomination. Some things are originally local; some are general. Even originally local matters may become general, through review, complaint,

or appeal.

1. Local Courts: (Session)

1 Cor. 5:11-13

2. Higher Courts: (Presbytery and Assembly)

Acts 15: 1-6

Acts 16:4

Note: Decrees made by court (Acts 15) constituted a standard for the churches to follow.

Questions that illustrate why one form of government is more biblical than others.

1. Biblically, are doctrinal matters local or general? Acts 15. Does the church at Antioch settle the issue of the status of Gentiles in the NT church, or is this issue settled by a general council?

2. Biblically, are disciplinary matters local or general? 1 Cor. 5. Does Paul remove the sinning individual from Corinth, or does he require the Corinthians to remove him?

3. Biblically, are diaconal matters local or general? 1 Cor. 16. Are the saints at Galatia and Corinth responsible for the relief of saints at Jerusalem, or is such relief the responsibility of the Jerusalem saints?

4. Biblically, are missionary matters local or general? 2 Cor. 8. Did the Macedonians' gift to Paul contribute to "ministering to the saints" only in Macedonia or elsewhere as well, and does Paul exhort the Corinthians to abound in this grace also? Similarly, did the Philippians contribute to Paul's sustenance as a minister only while he was in Phillipi, or when he was in Thessalonica also (Phil. 4)?

Excursus: *The Westminster Standards*

Ashbel Green comments that "the Catechism on which the subsequent lectures are to be founded is the production of some of the most learned and pious divines that ever lived." (p.30) This estimation of the quality of people assembled to develop a system of Faith derived from the teachings of the Bible is not unique. Philip Schaff, perhaps one of the most respected historians of the church and church creeds, could say about the Westminster Assembly that "whether we look at the extent or ability of its labors, or its influence upon future generations, it stands first among Protestant Councils." (p.728, *The Creeds of Christendom*, Vol. 1) He later quotes Anglican Puritan Richard Baxter, although himself not a member of the Assembly but well qualified under any estimation to evaluate its quality as saying;

The divines there congregated were men of eminent learning, godliness, ministerial abilities, and fidelity; and being not worthy to be one of them myself, I may the more freely speak the truth even in the face of malice and envy, that as far as I am able to judge by the information of all history of that kind, and by any other evidences left us, the Christian world since the days of the apostles had never a synod of more excellent divines than this and the Synod of Dort." (p.729, Schaff)

The Westminster Assembly occupied about five years and six months for the completion of its proper work. (July 1, 1643- February 22, 1649) It held no less than 1163 regular sessions. It met every day except Saturday and Sunday, from nine o'clock till one or two in the afternoon. The afternoons were spent in committees. The divines which attended

consisted of 121 men from several different affiliations such as Episcopalian, the Belgic, French, Helvetic and other Reformed Churches, Presbyterians, etc. . There were two classes of Presbyterians corresponding to the Low and High Church Episcopalians.

The significance of such facts ought to jump out to the modern reader. Yes, we could start from scratch and develop our own interpretation of scripture. In fact, every student of the Bible necessarily does this in the very process of understanding and digesting it's teaching. And if we refuse the assistance afforded by the statements of doctrine that were meticulously and cautiously elaborated and defined by the church over a period of 1163 intensive days by some of the most able of men in the church's history, we must then make out our own creed by our own unaided wisdom. So the real question is really not whether or not we have a creed. Every time we use the scripture to determine our belief, we have in effect created one. The real question is will we be humble and wise enough to utilize the great wealth of wisdom represented in such a document as the Westminster Confession of Faith. Common sense tells us we should consider the collected wisdom of the church throughout the ages as represented in our church's creed. And why not give our children the added benefit of not being left to the hurried attempts of even the most ambitious modern teacher. So we at Christ Presbyterian, while never relinquishing our responsibility to teach our children, will humbly utilize those grand statements of faith that might provide greater depth and less error in what we do teach.